

How the Chinese Government Fabricates Social Media Posts for Strategic Distraction, not Engaged Argument¹

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Northeastern University, 9/26/2016

¹Based on joint work with Jennifer Pan (Stanford) and Margaret Roberts (UCSD)

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Papers

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- Empirical Results:

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China's Highly Contested Social Media Landscape

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- > 1,400 diverse sites, fast changing, technological arm's race



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- Compared to contested physical spaces (e.g., South China Sea), social media: is more consequential for the regime & its people, has more intrusive government controls,

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 - Common name: “50c Party” members

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 - Disagreements between central and local leaders

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“posting information favorable to the regime and chastising its critics” (Deibert and Rohozinski, 2010)

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“undercover pro-government Internet commenters” (Foreign Policy)

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“neutralize undesirable public opinion by pushing pro-Party views” (Far Eastern Economic Review)

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"If you oppose the US and Japan [online], you are a member of the 50 cents army" (artist-dissident Ai Weiwei)

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“Combat hostile energy [which should be] resolutely resisted, proactively refuted, and eagerly reported to Internet authorities” (Haley, 2012)

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We collected people accused on social media of being 50c:

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65% *argue* with critics of the regime

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It's antisestablishmentarianism!

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Evidence?

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- **Distracts**; redirects public attention from criticism and central issues to **cheerleading** and positive discussions of valence issues

First Systematic Evidence on China's 50c Party

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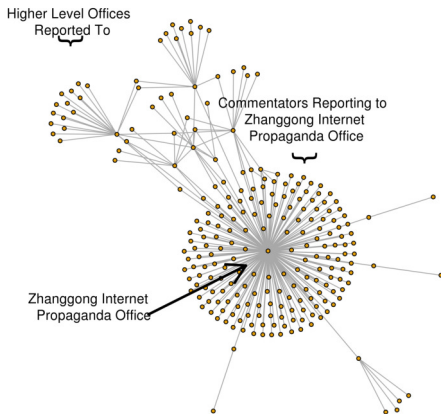
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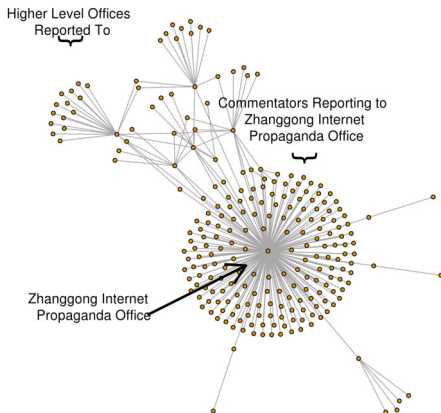
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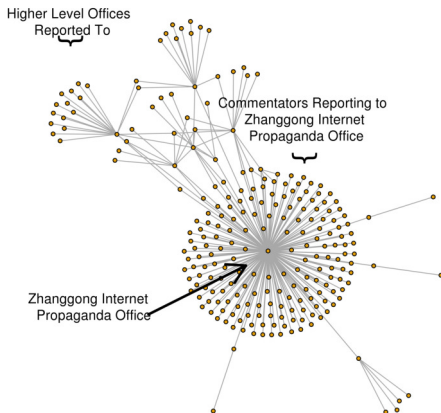


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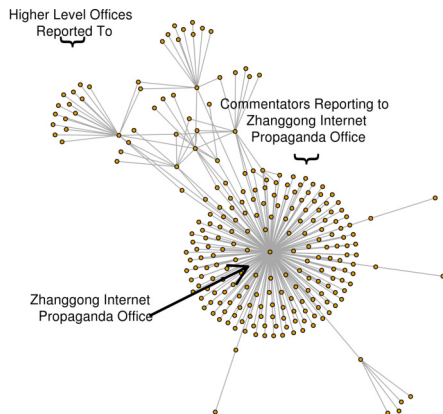
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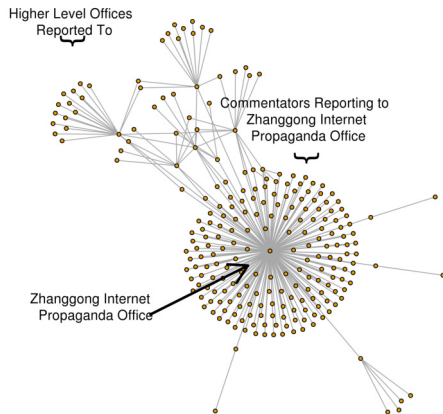
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 - **In fact:** 99.3% of posts made by >200 government offices
 - **No evidence of 50c (or any piecemeal) payments;** probably part of their jobs

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Categories and Analyses of 50c Party Posts

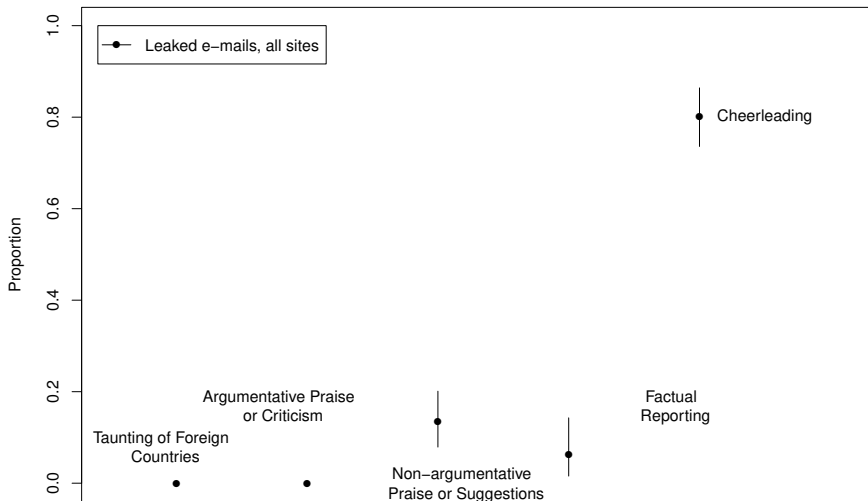
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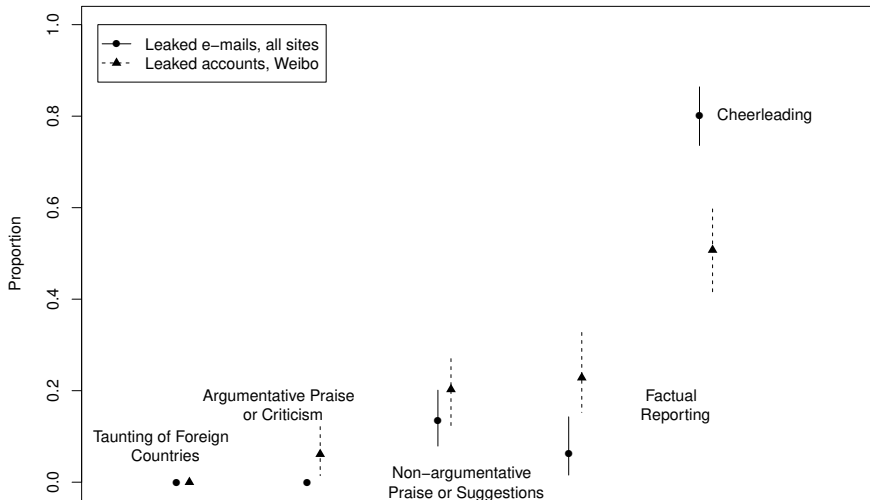
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Content of Leaked and Predicted 50c Party Posts

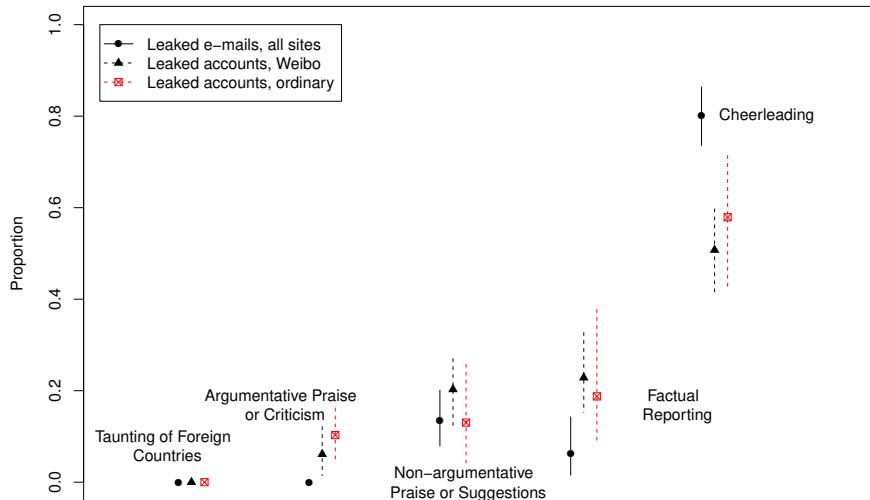
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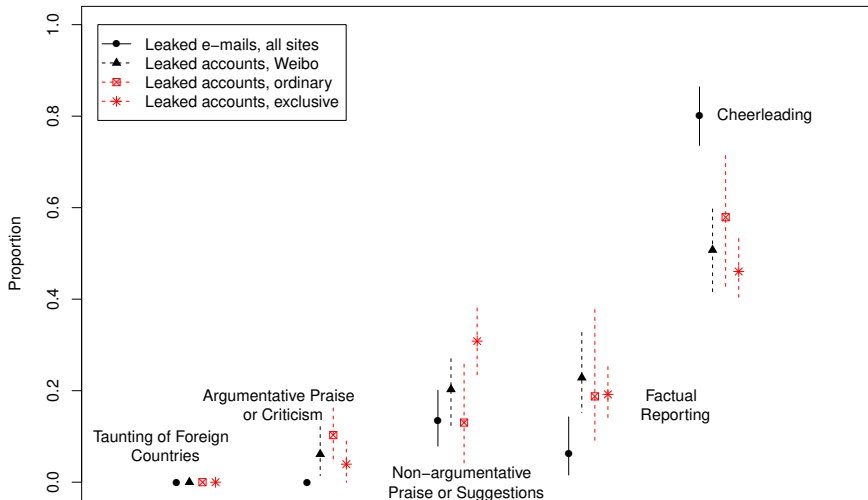
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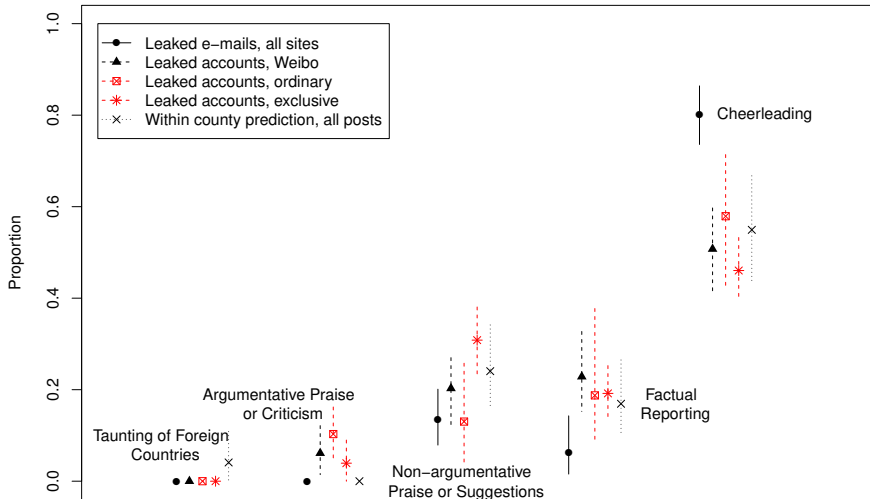
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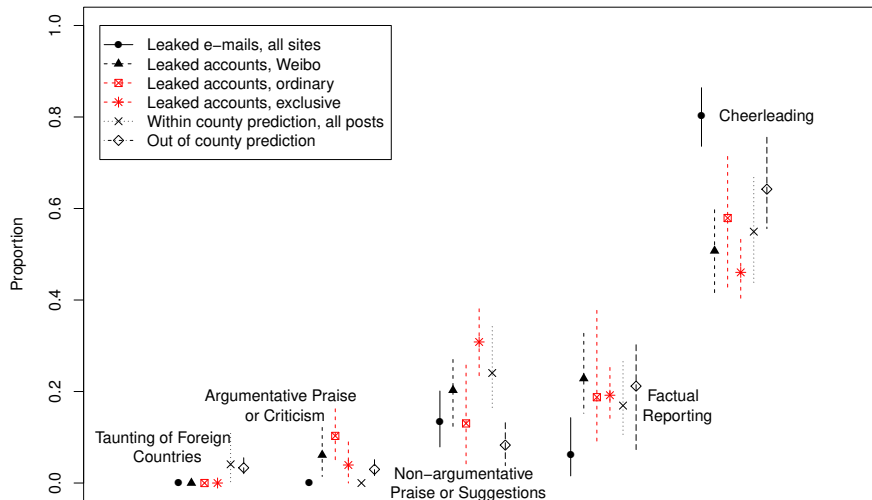
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Size of the 50c Party (in 2013)

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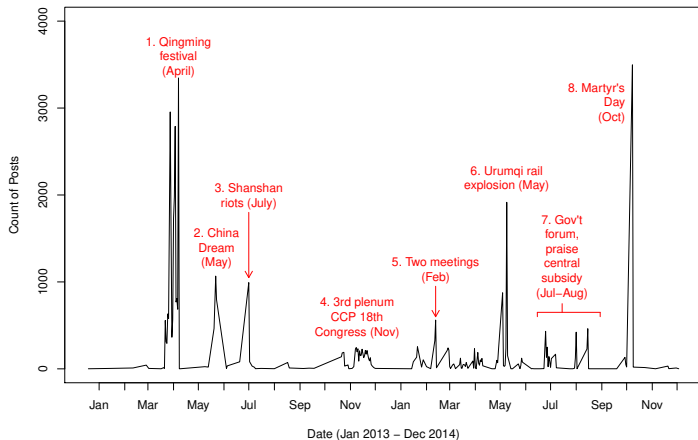
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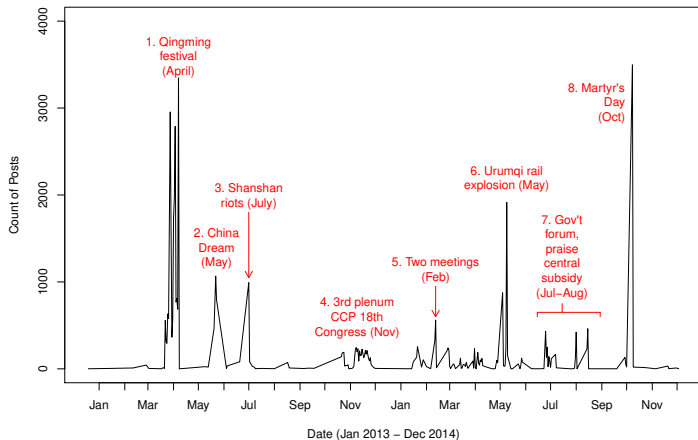
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 - 53% on government sites (a noticeable proportion of all)
 - 47% on commercial sites (1 of every 178 posts)

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Coordinated bursts, many for events with collective action potential

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 - Ask same question of accounts *known not to be* 50c

Survey Validation of 50c Party Membership Predictions

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50c Status

Origin

Percent Yes

Survey Validation of 50c Party Membership Predictions

50c Status	Origin	Percent Yes
Predicted 50c	Across China	

Survey Validation of 50c Party Membership Predictions

50c Status	Origin	Percent Yes
Predicted 50c	Across China	59%

Survey Validation of 50c Party Membership Predictions

50c Status	Origin	Percent Yes
Predicted 50c	Across China	59%
Known 50c	Leaked Zhanggong Archive	

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Known 50c	Leaked Zhanggong Archive	57%

Survey Validation of 50c Party Membership Predictions

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Known "Not" 50c	Random sample	

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50c Status	Origin	Percent Yes
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Predicted v. known: not significantly different

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For more information



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